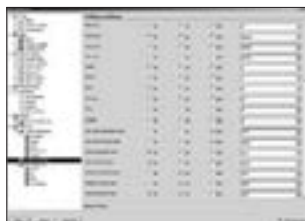


Concluding Remarks

For: VLC packs in more features than any other media player. By incorporating an editor and transcoder the need to have discrete applications for these jobs is minimised. Altering display properties is easy. The extensive audio settings and playlist functions also make it a formidable audio player.



Hot Key settings in VLC

Against: This true Open Source proponent shoots itself in the foot by insisting on using Open Source codecs only. VLC also does not use codecs installed in the system, rather uses those that it comes bundled with. So while it will play almost all video and audio files, out of the box, some files, such as Real Media audio and video cannot be played because their codecs are not Open Source. Also, the bundled encoding and cutting tool, though handy, is restricted. Glaringly, the full screen video mode does not have any controls (but the exhaustive hot key configuration helps)

VLC leaves out the all important Help file. But this would be needed only in case you wonder what the advanced settings were for. The manual can be downloaded from their site. Alternate skins need to be reapplied every session.

Overall, while it offers more than Media Player Classic, minor irritants mar the experience. It is definitely not the right solution for those who are looking for just a simple media player. However, people who are digitally adventurous will find that VLC hides a lot more than it reveals. Those who want to get their hands dirty will find that VLC Media Player is the Swiss army knife of their PCs.